wisdom of Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan and Ananda Coomaraswamy, learning about the lives of such notable figures as Swami Vivekananda, Ramakrishna Paramahamsa and Paramahansa Yogananda, and delving into a variety of scholarly studies, from the old classics by A. L. Basham and R. C. Zaehner to the brilliantly interpretative translations and exegeses of Raimon Panikkar and Dr Karan Singh. From these, and others, notably my own father, I had acquired a set of personal convictions that made up 'my' Hinduism. But was that enough, and what did it amount to in the face of a violent new assertion of Hinduness in a form I could not recognise as bearing any relation to my own faith?

DEFINING HINDUISM

The first challenge, of course, was definitional. The name 'Hindu' itself denotes something less, and more, than a set of theological beliefs. In many languages, French and Persian amongst them, the word for 'Indian' is 'Hindu'. Originally, *Hindu* simply meant the people beyond the River Sindhu, or Indus. But the Indus is now in Islamic Pakistan; and to make matters worse, the word 'Hindu' did not exist in any Indian language till its use by foreigners gave Indians a term for self-definition. Hindus, in other words, call themselves by a label that they didn't invent themselves in any of their own languages, but adopted cheerfully when others began to refer to them by that word. (Of course, many prefer a different term altogether—Sanatana Dharma, or eternal faith, which we will discuss later.)

'Hinduism' is thus the name that foreigners first applied to what they saw as the indigenous religion of India. It embraces an eclectic range of doctrines and practices, from pantheism to agnosticism and from faith in reincarnation to belief in the caste system. But none of these constitutes an obligatory credo for a Hindu: there are none. We have no compulsory dogmas.

This is, of course, rather unusual. A Catholic is a Catholic because he believes Jesus was the Son of God who sacrificed himself for Man; a Catholic believes in the Immaculate Conception and the Virgin Birth, offers confession, genuflects in church and is guided by the Pope and a celibate priesthood. A Muslim must believe that there is no God but